

WIRELESS ROUTERS

Speed is of the essence

When we last looked at Wi-Fi routers we assumed that we'd be seeing a lot more of AC5300 routers within the first half of 2016. Unfortunately, that didn't happen. Manufacturer's didn't sell much of the existing AC3200 routers which has made them a bit skeptical about the high-end market. Even now certain manufacturers who had promised to bring their AC5300 units have stopped and are observing the competition. And while all of this is going on, 802.11ad 7200 products have already begun selling in other markets. So suffice to say, we aren't going to see AD7200 Wi-Fi routers for a bit.

With Netflix already in India and Amazon Prime video coming soon, the need for routers that can handle multiple such streams should become widespread. And this rise wasn't expected to be driven purely by the need for more throughput but by the fact that more expensive routers can handle signal modulation better for an existing environment. The ability of newer routers to better manage clients and switching them between bands based on the type of data traffic has become a lot more efficient. So here are the winners.

ZERO1 WINNER

ASUS RT-AC5300

We've received two AC5300 units for the Zero1 awards, the other being TP-Link's Archer C5400. Between the two, the hardware at the core is pretty similar as the SoC for both are the same Qualcomm Atheros 4709 which then puts the onus on the brand to implement them in the



TP-LINK Archer C5400

Price: ₹22,900



D-LINK DIR-879

Price: ₹16,690



D-LINK DIR-842

Price: ₹3,099

most efficient manner possible. We check this by running throughput tests and then check for latency issues especially since most routers have started claiming to be optimised for gaming. We don't bother with this because of how the variables can change between testing different SKUs but pure throughput performance is something we test. The ASUS RT-AC5300 maintains a steady stream with little wavering which is optimal for any router. The design is best described by the word 'alien' as it does pretty much seem out of this world. Like upside down crabs. Since Zero1 is all about performance and the RT-AC5300 is the best we've had this year, it rightfully bags the first place.

RUNNER-UPS

TP-LINK Archer C5400 and D-LINK DIR-879

Coming right behind the ASUS RT-AC5300 is TP-Link's Archer C5400. As mentioned previously, the hardware is mostly the same. The firmware is a lot more easier to navigate through than mid-tier SKUs. Performance wise, the Archer C5400 is barely behind the ASUS unit and the peak throughput levels are only behind by a meagre amount. This makes the Archer C5400 a close second.

Moving on to the DIR-879, while we have received plenty of AC1900 routers, this is one of the 3 units we've received this year and by far does perform better than all previously received AC1900 routers. Design-wise it is quite similar to last year's winner, the DIR-890L except that this has fewer antennae. The peak throughput is lower than the other two flagships and that's why the D-LINK DIR-879 falls into third place.

BEST BUY

D-LINK DIR-842

It seems that AC1900 is still the sweet spot for getting a wireless router these days. However, AC1900 is not economical when you get the same units here in India. Even AC1750 routers which are generally priced around the ₹7,000 mark is a bit too much for the average consumer. So we're going to lower the bandwidth bar down to AC1200 and that's where we find D-LINK's DIR-842. It's a dual band router but the lack of ADSL is something which doesn't exactly bode well since ADSL is quite popular in the country. But given all the units we've received this year, this particular unit seems to be the best you can get for your money. Moreover, it has GbE ports so LAN transfers aren't slow either. **d**



ASUS RT-AC5300

Price: ₹23,000